



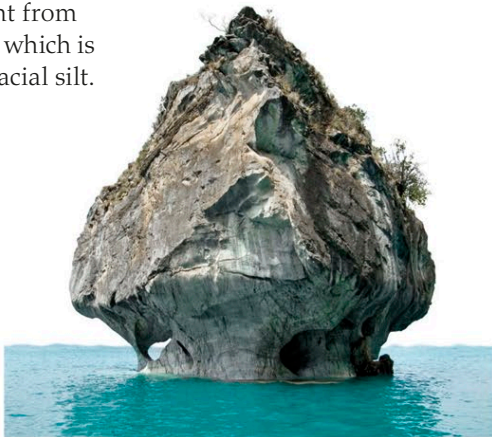
General Carrera Lake

A large glacial lake in the shadow of the Andes with a remarkable complex of carved marble caves on its shores

General Carrera Lake, also known as Lake Buenos Aires, spans the border between Chile and Argentina in Patagonia. With a surface area of 715 square miles (1,850 square km), it is the second largest freshwater lake in South America, after Lake Titicaca (see p.105). General Carrera Lake is surrounded by the Andes, and its glacier-fed water drains into the Pacific Ocean through the Baker River, the largest river in Chile. Its most famous feature, known as the Marble Cathedral, or Marble Caves, is a series of pure marble cliffs that have been carved into elaborate caves, tunnels, and columns by 10,000 years of wave action. The smoothly formed light-gray rock takes on a blue tint from the surrounding water, which is colored turquoise by glacial silt.

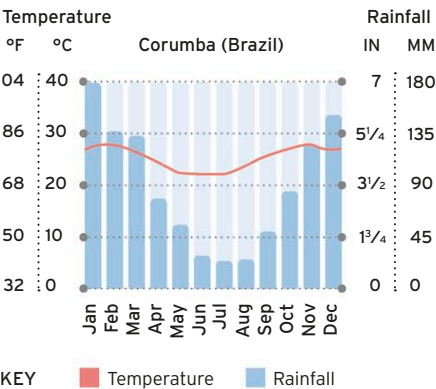
SCULPTURED MARBLE

The Marble Cathedral system includes an island monolith known as the Marble Chapel. The clarity of the water of General Carrera Lake reveals how the rock formations continue below the surface.



CLIMATE

The Pantanal has a tropical climate with a hot rainy season and a drier season during the cooler months. The extent and depth of floodwaters vary greatly throughout the year.



FLOODED PLAINS
Around 80 percent of the Pantanal's vast plains are inundated during the wet season, as water levels rise by up to 16 ft (5 m).